worries as he rattled off the names of at least four constituencies in his district where the BJP and his NCP faction continue to have a bristling relationship.

The BJP's minor allies like the RSP are also upset at being left out of the power matrix. Jankar, farmer leader Sadabhau Khot of the Rayat Kranti Sanghatana (RKS), and RPI veteran Avinash Mahatekar were ministers in the pre-2019 BJP-Sena coalition government. However, ministerial berths have eluded these smaller parties with the three major players in the government jostling for the spoils. "I am planning to contest the Lok Sabha election from two seats," says Jankar, a two-term MLC whose RSP has one MLA in Maharashtra. He bemoaned the fact that "larger parties eat up smaller ones".

Incidentally, Jankar was not invited for the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) meeting in Delhi on July 18. From Maharashtra, Shinde, Ajit, Union minister Ramdas Athawale of the Republican Party of India (RPI-A), Prahar Janashakti Party leader Omprakash (Bacchu) Kadu, and cooperatives baron Vinay Kore Savkar, who heads the Kolhapur-based Jana Surajya Shakti (JSS), were among the invitees. The RKS's Khot was also not invited. "The old allies who had taken on established rivals were left out...the BJP was like an elder brother, they should have taken us along," he says with some bitterness. ■



Kumaraswamy who led the attack on the ruling party. For instance, when he claimed he had details of a racket in official transfers.

The informal solidarity between the JD(S) and the BJP extended to a joint boycott of assembly proceedings last week. Accusing the Siddaramaiah government of 'misusing' the bureaucracy—for deputing IAS officers to receive the Congress's political guests at the INDIA conclave—BJP legislators had protested in the House, leading to the suspension of 10 MLAs. JD(S) legislators signed on a BJP memorandum to the governor on the issue, and Kumaraswamy held a rare joint press conference on July 21 with former CM Basavaraj Bommai of the BJP. "We have decided to jointly fight this government, both on the floor and outside," Kumaraswamy announced, adding that they would proceed on a 'mutual understanding'. Among the issues he highlighted were the stalling of welfare schemes for farmers started by the previous BJP regime and 'irregularities' in the Bengaluru-Mysore Infrastructure Corridor.

GOWDA SAYS THE JD(S) WILL FIGHT THE GENERAL ELECTION ALONE BUT THE DOOR HE LEFT OPEN FOR 'POST-POLL' ALLIANCE IS SIGNAL ENOUGH

But all that hyperlocal content doesn't detract from one key fact: the BJP's real focus is 2024, and the utility it sees in the JD(S) relates to how a synergy can be worked out in terms of Lok Sabha seats. And the JD(S)'s canniness will lie in how it segues into that plan.

Among the three parties, the BJP has consistently won the highest number of Lok Sabha seats in Karnataka for four elections now. In the 2019 election, the Congress and JD(S) contested as allies but ended up conceding all but two of the 28 constituencies to the BJP. The saffron party won 19 seats in 2009 and 17 in 2014 while the Congress tally for the same elections were six and nine seats, respectively. The JD(S) won three seats in 2009 and two in 2014. What if it leans to the other side?

Many JD(S) partymen aren't averse to a tie-up with the BJP since their voter base doesn't overlap, says a party functionary. Some, in fact, reckon it could benefit the JD(S) in parts of Old Mysuru like Kolar, Tumkur and Mandya, where its primary rival is the Congress. That's theoretical, for now. While the party is fine with coordinating in the assembly, JD(S) supremo H.D. Deve Gowda on July 25 ruled out an alliance with either side for 2024. "We don't know how many seats we will win... it could be 10 or 2. But we will fight independently, there's no doubt about that," he said at a presser, adding that any decision on a post-poll alliance will depend on the circumstances that emerge, and "helping bring a stable government at the Centre".

That last line leaves the door open. Since the assembly election defeat, the BJP has struggled with infighting and the JD(S) too finds itself at a low ebb, while the Congress is betting on its welfare schemes to deliver a bonanza in the LS polls. Whether formal or implicit, a joint BJP-JD(S) manoeuvre can conceivably alter that picture. ■